

category while other software such as Eyeball, Im4cam, Paltalk and the like fall into the latter. Though all these software integrate text, voice and video, they differ in the balance of the features that they offer.

Go fishing on the Web

First up, the chat tools that we are familiar with. Yahoo! and MSN both provide the facility for video and voice chat. You can choose either of these conventional clients depending on which one you are more used to. All chat software recognise the default video input device and auto-configure themselves to the available input device.

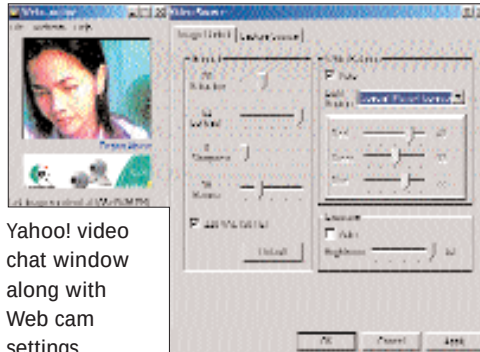
Installation isn't a major hassle with Yahoo!. It has an easy-to-grasp interface, which doesn't confuse you with too many options to choose from. To enable video chatting, all you have to do is plug your camera into the appropriate socket in your computer and choose 'Start Web cam' from the Tools menu. A small window pops up in which you can see the image captured by the camera. Camera adjustments such as brightness, contrast, gamma, saturation, etc can be done from the Preferences option in the Tools menu.

Once your camera is all set up, you will see two buttons pop up in the window. If you want your friends to see you on the Web cam, click on the broadcast button and the messenger connects you to Yahoo! video server, which delivers the video directly to the person who requests to see your camera. Viewing privileges can be set in the same Preferences option as above.

Once you start broadcasting, your status message automatically changes to the default message, 'View my Web cam'. This message can be changed or disabled from the Preferences for the Web cam. Disabling the status messages while on camera helps you avoid unwanted peeping toms. Yahoo! also lets you report any abuse that you

might come across while videoconferencing by simply clicking on the Report Abuse option in the video window of any person who is trying to send you objectionable material.

Netmeeting is Microsoft's proprietary software for videoconferencing. MSN uses Netmeeting, which is a separate program that launches when you start videoconferencing. You



Yahoo! video chat window along with Web cam settings

can download Netmeeting from Microsoft's site. You don't need any additional installations to use this program, except for a one-time configuration, which might require you to fill in a registration form, certain details regarding your connectivity and related information.

After launching the software, enter the MSN passport of the person you would like to conference with and click on the Call button. Once the connection is established, the person's picture will be visible on the right-hand window.

Others in the Net

Now on to video chat clients. Installing Eyeball software is very simple. Register with the Eyeball service and login with your ID and password. Eyeball has a glamorous, graphics-rich and complex interface. You can add friends as in any instant messenger and also search for chat

Video Broadcasting

Video broadcast over the Net has been made much simpler for home users. There are lots of free services on the Net, which allow you to stream or broadcast video. These are basic services that you can use as an evaluation before upgrading yourself to the premium services offered by these companies.

www.webcamnow.com provides you software that is free for download, with the aid of which you could broadcast live video over the Net. Go to the site, create an ID and download the broadcast software. Install the software and login with the ID you created, and you are ready to broadcast. You can see your broadcast in the community area you joined while creating the ID. The site hosts livecams, which can be viewed from any Java enabled browser.

You can use the iClips service (www.iclips.com) to create and upload streaming movies on your Yahoo! profiles. A free registration, and you are entitled to 20 MB of free space on the iClips streaming servers. You could request for more space and streaming features by contacting iClips. Share a preview of your new house or your baby walking, with friends all over the world. You could even put up an advertisement for your product with a small video on your profile.

Buying a Web cam?

Be smart. Apart from good looks you should check out other features while purchasing your Web cam. The list given below will give you an idea of what kind of Web cam you should opt for:

Resolution: A camera's quality is weighed against the resolution that it supports and offers. So choose one that offers a good resolution. Look for one that offers the capability of capturing images at 640x480, at the very least.

Connectivity: Check for USB connectivity as USB is faster and is far easier to configure than other interfaces.

FPS at high resolution: Watch out for the frame rates that the camera supports at high

resolutions. This is important as otherwise the video quality would be poor when in high-resolution mode—15 fps is a good frame rate for videoconferencing.

Software and drivers: You might get a better deal for a cheaper price but may not be able to get the accompanying drivers and software. You would do better to buy a camera that comes with software drivers, which would reduce the headache of hunting the Net for the desired drivers.

Price: Needless to say, buy something that suits your pocket but keep the above points in mind while making an investment so that you get your money's worth.